

LAST?

Despite the rapid spread of H1N1 virus in India, mortality rates are still low and it is not as deadly as was feared. But the danger remains.

| By Damayanti Datta |

One week, 17 deaths and over 1,000 confirmed cases. You can count the days on your fingers, but not the victims of the new public health menace—the H1N1 flu. “Its speed is without precedent,” says Dr Randeep Guleria, professor of Internal Medicine at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). “It has spread more in less than six weeks than influenza viruses did in six months in past pandemics. It has gone to more than 22 cities and towns in the country.”

The mysterious flu, that set the world atwitter, lurched toward India—almost reluctantly—in May, when a 23-year-old Indian carried the virus from New York to Hyderabad. But with 332 health workers screening 45,000 passengers at 21 airports, June saw just 35 confirmed cases. Even by mid-July, the numbers stayed reassuringly low at 285.

Enter August and just as the World Health Organisation (WHO) quietly abandoned its flu count in countries like the US where it had spread rapidly and everybody started hoping H1N1 would not be interested in India—the flu slammed ashore. Within a week, both the infection rate and the death rate zoomed. Not just in Pune, Mumbai or Delhi. From Meghalaya to

Jalandhar, Bangalore to Lucknow, Hyderabad to Ajmer, Jammu to Thiruvananthapuram, Varanasi to Vadodara—the pandemic's progress is creating panic and pandemonium.

Panic has gripped the “worried well”. Television channels are giving updates on war-footing; schools are shutting shop at the first whiff of flu from students, making parents jittery; they are in turn locking up children indoors (no birthday parties, no outdoor romps); if footfalls are falling in stores that sell ham and pork, they are picking up at chemists that stock face-masks; Delhi stores are selling 10,000 a day these days compared to 1,000 a month in pre-H1N1 times. “Panic really makes our job tough,” says Dr N.K. Chaturvedi, medical superintendent of Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital, Delhi, where people have been trooping in hordes at the slightest sign of fever or cough to get tested.

But then, the influenza virus does like jerking people around. WHO describes it as “sloppy, capricious, and promiscuous”. You can call H1N1 sloppy: although a potentially deadly Type A virus, researchers claim its genetic code appears to lack key mutations that made past pandemic-causing viruses so deadly. You can call H1N1 capricious, because it is notoriously unpredictable: no one knows what form it will take



The US tops the list with **436** deaths and over **50,000** H1N1 cases.

Mortality rates are low with only **8** out of **1,000** infected people dying.

If infection rates spread, it could impact global GDP growth by up to